

Editorial

Dear Readers,

Rahul got busy with a major electronics event this time, so I've been asked to fill in. You may already be aware of the many BIG announcements made in February. First, the Symbian source code was released as open source. Second, Intel's (or the Linux Foundation's) Moblin and Nokia's Maemo project merged as MeeGo. Third, Android was all over the place at the Mobile World Congress 2010, held at Barcelona. You'll get to read about all this in the FOSS Bytes section. However, one BIG news that you won't get to read anywhere else in this issue, and which has nothing to do with mobile operating systems, is the release of KDE 4.4.

I'll get to the excuses on why we didn't (or couldn't) cover it, later. This release is a grand one with lots of feature additions—most of which aren't even that obvious. For example, the ability to group multiple windows together, enabling different apps to appear as tabs on KWin's title bar.

When I first tried this feature while testing out one of the beta releases a couple of months back, I couldn't figure out the need for it. If you look at it, the task manager lists all the open windows of apps that are running—so, what's the use of further grouping windows together to have them appear as tabs on top of the screen. If I want to switch to another tab to access another application, I can do that by either using the Alt-Tab keystroke, or clicking the respective apps on the task bar.

Fast forward to today, and I find this feature a must-have! Why? Because I've learned of a way to use it. Some apps open two or more windows at a time—for example, Kopete, VirtualBox, etc. The task manager will typically group these apps together to save some real estate—but I don't really have much control on how they are grouped. Then there is OpenOffice.org, on which I typically have a spreadsheet and a few documents open, at once. Now, with the KWin tabbing feature, I can manually group the windows that I am simultaneously working on—helps me become more organized :-)

Another cool feature is the Nepomuk-Akonadi-Strigi combo. Things are still rough, but they don't have that big question mark about their future anymore—I am speaking from the point of view of a regular user, who just wants to get the work done. For example, for the first time, I did manage to use the desktop search quite easily—it always had been a pain. I still had to google

to find ways to fix some issues with both Akonadi and Strigi, but I'm sure distro packagers would be able to iron out these problems easily.

Anyway, an editorial is only a page long so I have

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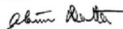
to cut this short. (How Rahul manages to speak his mind every month, within just one page, is a mystery to me.) Since I don't have space to talk about all the things I like and dislike in this release, I'd request you to visit the 'Visual Guide to KDE 4.4' at www.kde.org/announcements/4.4/guide.php. The reason we avoided talking about it in FOSS Bytes is because the above URL is a much better resource.

Why I couldn't write a review is because the month was short, and I wasted too much time in compiling a KDE 4.4 live DVD using SUSE Studio, which never saw the light of day. Our friend, Boudhayan Gupta, told me it worked on his desktop—in fact, it even worked on my desktop, wonderfully. But it just failed to recognise the keyboards and touchpads of all the laptops we tried it on—there's some package I kept missing out on, which I wasn't able to figure out :-)

The idea was to include Firefox 3.6, OpenOffice.org 3.2, VirtualBox 3.1, multimedia apps and codecs, and the whole of KDE 4.4—basically a one-stop-shop for your desktop needs. Let's see if we can figure out the hardware compatibility issues by next month and bundle the Live DVD.

(How do you end an editorial? Oh well...)

Best,



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